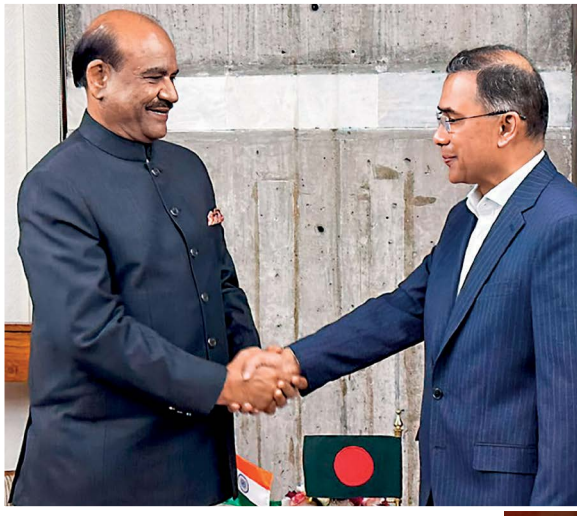
NEW ORDE
OLD TENSIO

How New Delhi should deal with the new Tarique Rahman regime in Dhaka

By **ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR** *in Dhaka &* **RAJ CHENGAPPA**

To take oath as the new prime minister of Bangladesh, Tarique Rahman decided to break with convention. Instead of Bangabhaban, the official residence of the President, he and his cabinet were sworn in at the expansive and public-facing Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban, home to the country's Parliament. It signalled the return of parliamentary democracy after more than a year and a half of rule by an interim administration that many in Bangladesh viewed as technocratic, opaque and increasingly unaccountable. Rahman walked to the venue in a black suit and white shirt, flanked by his wife, Dr Zubaida, and their daughter, Zaima. Those close to him remarked on the remarkable calm he exuded—one that he has built over the years and which has come to define his demeanour.

Both his parents, the late General Ziaur Rahman and Begum Khaleda Zia, had presided over Bangladesh's political destiny during crucial periods, giving the young Tarique both extraordinary exposure and easy familiarity with power. During Khaleda's second term as prime minister (2001-2006), Rahman began to take control of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) that she headed. But soon after, the military-backed interim government in 2007 charged him with heinous crimes, and the Sheikh Hasina-led Awami League won the 2008 election, forcing him to go into self-imposed exile to London. But though Rahman was away from the country, he was never far from its politics (see box, *The Long Walk to Premiership*). The Hasina government convicted him on multiple charges, and it would take 17 years for Rahman to return to Bangladesh, to take charge of the BNP campaign for the 2026 general election. He lost his mother to illness soon after but has now led the BNP alliance to a phenomenal victory, winning 212 out of the 300



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